

Chapter IV

Captivity: The Fourth Day



THE next day, when Felton entered Milady's apartment he found her standing, mounted upon a chair, holding in her hands a cord made by means of torn cambric handkerchiefs, twisted into a kind of rope one with another, and tied at the ends. At the noise Felton made in entering, Milady leaped lightly to the ground, and tried to conceal behind her the improvised cord she held in her hand.

The young man was more pale than usual, and his eyes, reddened by want of sleep, denoted that he had passed a feverish night. Nevertheless, his brow was armed with a severity more austere than ever.

He advanced slowly toward Milady, who had seated herself, and taking an end of the murderous rope which by neglect, or perhaps by design, she allowed to be seen, 'What is this, madame?' he asked coldly.

'That? Nothing,' said Milady, smiling with that painful expression which she knew so well how to give to her smile. 'Ennuï is the mortal enemy of prisoners; I had ennui, and I amused myself with twisting that rope.'

Felton turned his eyes toward the part of the wall of the apartment before which he had found Milady standing in the armchair in which she was now seated, and over her head he perceived a gilt-headed screw, fixed in the wall for the purpose of hanging up clothes or weapons.

He started, and the prisoner saw that start—for though her eyes were cast down, nothing escaped her.

'What were you doing on that armchair?' asked he.

'Of what consequence?' replied Milady.

'But,' replied Felton, 'I wish to know.'

‘Do not question me,’ said the prisoner; ‘you know that we who are true Christians are forbidden to lie.’

‘Well, then,’ said Felton, ‘I will tell you what you were doing, or rather what you meant to do; you were going to complete the fatal project you cherish in your mind. Remember, madame, if our God forbids falsehood, he much more severely condemns suicide.’

‘When God sees one of his creatures persecuted unjustly, placed between suicide and dishonour, believe me, sir,’ replied Milady, in a tone of deep conviction, ‘God pardons suicide, for then suicide becomes martyrdom.’

‘You say either too much or too little; speak, madame. In the name of heaven, explain yourself.’

‘That I may relate my misfortunes for you to treat them as fables; that I may tell you my projects for you to go and betray them to my persecutor? No, sir. Besides, of what importance to you is the life or death of a condemned wretch? You are only responsible for my body, is it not so? And provided you produce a carcass that may be recognized as mine, they will require no more of you; nay, perhaps you will even have a double reward.’

‘I, madame, I?’ cried Felton. ‘You suppose that I would ever accept the price of your life? Oh, you cannot believe what you say!’

‘Let me act as I please, Felton, let me act as I please,’ said Milady, elated. ‘Every soldier must be ambitious, must he not? You are a lieutenant? Well, you will follow me to the grave with the rank of captain.’

‘What have I, then, done to you,’ said Felton, much agitated, ‘that you should load me with such a responsibility before God and before men? In a few days you will be away from this place; your life, madame, will then no longer be under my care, and,’ added he, with a sigh, ‘then you can do what you will with it.’

‘So,’ cried Milady, as if she could not resist giving utterance to a holy indignation, ‘you, a pious man, you who are called a just man, you ask but one thing—and that is that you may not be inculpated, annoyed, by my death!’

‘It is my duty to watch over your life, madame, and I will watch.’

‘But do you understand the mission you are fulfilling? Cruel enough, if I am guilty; but what name can you give it, what name will the Lord give it, if I am innocent?’

‘I am a soldier, madame, and fulfill the orders I have received.’

But although her voice—sweet, full, and sonorous—vibrated as harmoniously and as affectingly as ever, the door remained shut. It appeared however to Milady that in one of the furtive glances she darted from time to time at the grating of the door she thought she saw the ardent eyes of the young man through the narrow opening. But whether this was reality or vision, he had this time sufficient self-command not to enter.

However, a few instants after she had finished her religious song, Milady thought she heard a profound sigh. Then the same steps she had heard approach slowly withdrew, as if with regret.

‘Would you like better to be hanged in your true name, Milady? You know that the English laws are inexorable on the abuse of marriage. Speak freely. Although my name, or rather that of my brother, would be mixed up with the affair, I will risk the scandal of a public trial to make myself certain of getting rid of you.’

Milady made no reply, but became as pale as a corpse.

‘Oh, I see you prefer peregrination. That’s well, madame; and there is an old proverb that says, “Traveling trains youth.” My faith! you are not wrong after all, and life is sweet. That’s the reason why I take such care you shall not deprive me of mine. There only remains, then, the question of the five shillings to be settled. You think me rather parsimonious, don’t you? That’s because I don’t care to leave you the means of corrupting your jailers. Besides, you will always have your charms left to seduce them with. Employ them, if your check with regard to Felton has not disgusted you with attempts of that kind.’

‘Felton has not told him,’ said Milady to herself. ‘Nothing is lost, then.’

‘And now, madame, till I see you again! Tomorrow I will come and announce to you the departure of my messenger.’

Lord de Winter rose, saluted her ironically, and went out.

Milady breathed again. She had still four days before her. Four days would quite suffice to complete the seduction of Felton.

A terrible idea, however, rushed into her mind. She thought that Lord de Winter would perhaps send Felton himself to get the order signed by the Duke of Buckingham. In that case Felton would escape her—for in order to secure success, the magic of a continuous seduction was necessary. Nevertheless, as we have said, one circumstance reassured her. Felton had not spoken.

As she would not appear to be agitated by the threats of Lord de Winter, she placed herself at the table and ate.

Then, as she had done the evening before, she fell on her knees and repeated her prayers aloud. As on the evening before, the soldier stopped his march to listen to her.

Soon after she heard lighter steps than those of the sentinel, which came from the end of the corridor and stopped before her door.

‘It is he,’ said she. And she began the same religious chant which had so strongly excited Felton the evening before.

‘Do you believe, then, that at the day of the Last Judgment God will separate blind executioners from iniquitous judges? You are not willing that I should kill my body, and you make yourself the agent of him who would kill my soul!’

‘But I repeat it again to you,’ replied Felton, in great emotion, ‘no danger threatens you; I will answer for Lord de Winter as for myself.’

‘Dunce,’ cried Milady, ‘dunce! who dares to answer for another man, when the wisest, when those most after God’s own heart, hesitate to answer for themselves, and who ranges himself on the side of the strongest and the most fortunate, to crush the weakest and the most unfortunate.’

‘Impossible, madame, impossible,’ murmured Felton, who felt to the bottom of his heart the justness of this argument. ‘A prisoner, you will not recover your liberty through me; living, you will not lose your life through me.’

‘Yes,’ cried Milady, ‘but I shall lose that which is much dearer to me than life, I shall lose my honour, Felton; and it is you, you whom I make responsible, before God and before men, for my shame and my infamy.’

This time Felton, immovable as he was, or appeared to be, could not resist the secret influence which had already taken possession of him. To see this woman, so beautiful, fair as the brightest vision, to see her by turns overcome with grief and threatening; to resist at once the ascendancy of grief and beauty—it was too much for a visionary; it was too much for a brain weakened by the ardent dreams of an ecstatic faith; it was too much for a heart furrowed by the love of heaven that burns, by the hatred of men that devours.

Milady saw the trouble. She felt by intuition the flame of the opposing passions which burned with the blood in the veins of the young fanatic. As a skilful general, seeing the enemy ready to surrender, marches toward him with a cry of victory, she rose, beautiful as an antique priestess, inspired like a Christian virgin, her arms extended, her throat uncovered, her hair dishevelled, holding with one hand her robe modestly drawn over her breast, her look illumined by that fire which had already created such disorder in the veins of the young Puritan, and went toward him, crying out with a vehement air, and in her melodious voice, to which on this occasion she communicated a terrible energy:

Let this victim to Baal be sent,
To the lions the martyr be thrown!
Thy God shall teach thee to repent!
From th' abyss he'll give ear to my moan.

Felton stood before this strange apparition like one petrified.

'Who art thou? Who art thou?' cried he, clasping his hands. 'Art thou a messenger from God; art thou a minister from hell; art thou an angel or a demon; callest thou thyself Eloa or Astaré?'

'Do you not know me, Felton? I am neither an angel nor a demon; I am a daughter of earth, I am a sister of thy faith, that is all.'

'Yes, yes,' said Felton, 'I doubted, but now I believe.'

'You believe, and still you are an accomplice of that child of Belial who is called Lord de Winter! You believe, and yet you leave me in the hands of mine enemies, of the enemy of England, of the enemy of God! You believe, and yet you deliver me up to him who fills and defiles the world with his heresies and debaucheries—to that infamous Sardanapalus whom the blind call the Duke of Buckingham, and whom believers name Antichrist!'

'I deliver you up to Buckingham? I? what mean you by that?'

'They have eyes,' cried Milady, 'but they see not; ears have they, but they hear not.'

'Yes, yes!' said Felton, passing his hands over his brow, covered with sweat, as if to remove his last doubt. 'Yes, I recognize the voice which speaks to me in my dreams; yes, I recognize the features of the angel who appears to me every night, crying to my soul, which cannot sleep: "Strike, save England, save thyself—for thou wilt die without having appeared God!" Speak, speak!' cried Felton, 'I can understand you now.'

A flash of terrible joy, but rapid as thought, gleamed from the eyes of Milady.

However fugitive this homicide flash, Felton saw it, and started as if its light had revealed the abysses of this woman's heart. He recalled, all at once, the warnings of Lord de Winter, the seductions of Milady, her first attempts after her arrival. He drew back a step, and hung down his head, without, however, ceasing to look at her, as if, fascinated by this strange creature, he could not detach his eyes from her eyes.

Then turning his eyes from Milady to the paper, he read: "Order to conduct—" The name is blank,' interrupted Lord de Winter. 'If you have any preference you can point it out to me; and if it be not within a thousand leagues of London, attention will be paid to your wishes. I will begin again, then: "Order to conduct to—the person named Charlotte Backson, branded by the justice of the kingdom of France, but liberated after chastisement. She is to dwell in this place without ever going more than three leagues from it. In case of any attempt to escape, the penalty of death is to be applied. She will receive five shillings per day for lodging and food."

'That order does not concern me,' replied Milady, coldly, 'since it bears another name than mine.'

'A name? Have you a name, then?'

'I bear that of your brother.'

'Ay, but you are mistaken. My brother is only your second husband; and your first is still living. Tell me his name, and I will put it in the place of the name of Charlotte Backson. No? You will not? You are silent? Well, then you must be registered as Charlotte Backson.'

Milady remained silent; only this time it was no longer from affectation, but from terror. She believed the order ready for execution. She thought that Lord de Winter had hastened her departure; she thought she was condemned to set off that very evening. Everything in her mind was lost for an instant; when all at once she perceived that no signature was attached to the order. The joy she felt at this discovery was so great she could not conceal it.

'Yes, yes,' said Lord de Winter, who perceived what was passing in her mind; 'yes, you look for the signature, and you say to yourself: "All is not lost, for that order is not signed. It is only shown to me to terrify me, that's all." You are mistaken. Tomorrow this order will be sent to the Duke of Buckingham. The day after tomorrow it will return signed by his hand and marked with his seal; and four-and-twenty hours afterward I will answer for its being carried into execution. Adieu, madame. That is all I had to say to you.'

'And I reply to you, sir, that this abuse of power, this exile under a fictitious name, are infamous!'

Felton gently repulsed Milady, and she sank into a chair.

Lord de Winter passed before the door without stopping, and they heard the noise of his footsteps soon die away.

Felton, as pale as death, remained some instants with his ear bent and listening; then, when the sound was quite extinct, he breathed like a man awaking from a dream, and rushed out of the apartment.

‘Ah!’ said Milady, listening in her turn to the noise of Felton’s steps, which withdrew in a direction opposite to those of Lord de Winter; ‘at length you are mine!’

Then her brow darkened. ‘If he tells the baron,’ said she, ‘I am lost—for the baron, who knows very well that I shall not kill myself, will place me before him with a knife in my hand, and he will discover that all this despair is but acted.’

She placed herself before the glass, and regarded herself attentively; never had she appeared more beautiful.

‘Oh, yes,’ said she, smiling, ‘but we won’t tell him!’

In the evening Lord de Winter accompanied the supper.

‘Sir,’ said Milady, ‘is your presence an indispensable accessory of my captivity? Could you not spare me the increase of torture which your visits cause me?’

‘How, dear sister!’ said Lord de Winter. ‘Did not you sentimentally inform me with that pretty mouth of yours, so cruel to me today, that you came to England solely for the pleasure of seeing me at your ease, an enjoyment of which you told me you so sensibly felt the deprivation that you had risked everything for it—seasickness, tempest, captivity? Well, here I am; be satisfied. Besides, this time, my visit has a motive.’

Milady trembled; she thought Felton had told all. Perhaps never in her life had this woman, who had experienced so many opposite and powerful emotions, felt her heart beat so violently.

She was seated. Lord de Winter took a chair, drew it toward her, and sat down close beside her. Then taking a paper out of his pocket, he unfolded it slowly.

‘Here,’ said he, ‘I want to show you the kind of passport which I have drawn up, and which will serve you henceforward as the rule of order in the life I consent to leave you.’

Milady was not a woman to misunderstand the meaning of this hesitation. Under her apparent emotions her icy coolness never abandoned her. Before Felton replied, and before she should be forced to resume this conversation, so difficult to be sustained in the same exalted tone, she let her hands fall; and as if the weakness of the woman overpowered the enthusiasm of the inspired fanatic, she said: ‘But no, it is not for me to be the Judith to deliver Bethulia from this Holofernes. The sword of the eternal is too heavy for my arm. Allow me, then, to avoid dishonour by death; let me take refuge in martyrdom. I do not ask you for liberty, as a guilty one would, nor for vengeance, as would a pagan. Let me die; that is all. I supplicate you, I implore you on my knees—let me die, and my last sigh shall be a blessing for my preserver.’

Hearing that voice, so sweet and suppliant, seeing that look, so timid and downcast, Felton reproached himself. By degrees the enchantress had clothed herself with that magic adornment which she assumed and threw aside at will; that is to say, beauty, meekness, and tears—and above all, the irresistible attraction of mystical voluptuousness, the most devouring of all voluptuousness.

‘Alas!’ said Felton, ‘I can do but one thing, which is to pity you if you prove to me you are a victim! But Lord de Winter makes cruel accusations against you. You are a Christian; you are my sister in religion. I feel myself drawn toward you—I, who have never loved anyone but my benefactor—I who have met with nothing but traitors and impious men. But you, madame, so beautiful in reality, you, so pure in appearance, must have committed great iniquities for Lord de Winter to pursue you thus.’

‘They have eyes,’ repeated Milady, with an accent of indescribable grief, ‘but they see not; ears have they, but they hear not.’

‘But,’ cried the young officer, ‘speak, then, speak!’

‘Confide my shame to you,’ cried Milady, with the blush of modesty upon her countenance, ‘for often the crime of one becomes the shame of another—confide my shame to you, a man, and I a woman? Oh,’ continued she, placing her hand modestly over her beautiful eyes, ‘never! never!—I could not!’

‘To me, to a brother?’ said Felton.

Milady looked at him for some time with an expression which the young man took for doubt, but which, however, was nothing but observation, or rather the wish to fascinate.

Felton, in his turn a suppliant, clasped his hands.

'Well, then,' said Milady, 'I confide in my brother; I will dare to—'

At this moment the steps of Lord de Winter were heard, but this time the terrible brother-in-law of Milady did not content himself, as on the preceding day, with passing before the door and going away again. He paused, exchanged two words with the sentinel; then the door opened, and he appeared.

During the exchange of these two words Felton drew back quickly, and when Lord de Winter entered, he was several paces from the prisoner.

The baron entered slowly, sending a scrutinizing glance from Milady to the young officer.

'You have been here a very long time, John,' said he. 'Has this woman been relating her crimes to you? In that case I can comprehend the length of the conversation.'

Felton started, and Milady felt she was lost if she did not come to the assistance of the disconcerted Puritan.

'Ah, you fear your prisoner should escape!' said she. 'Well, ask your worthy jailer what favour I this instant solicited of him.'

'You demanded a favour?' said the baron, suspiciously.

'Yes, my Lord,' replied the young man, confused.

'And what favour, pray?' asked Lord de Winter.

'A knife, which she would return to me through the grating of the door a minute after she had received it,' replied Felton.

'There is someone, then, concealed here whose throat this amiable lady is desirous of cutting,' said de Winter, in an ironical, contemptuous tone.

'There is myself,' replied Milady.

'I have given you the choice between America and Tyburn,' replied Lord de Winter. 'Choose Tyburn, madame. Believe me, the cord is more certain than the knife.'

Felton grew pale, and made a step forward, remembering that at the moment he entered Milady had a rope in her hand.

'You are right,' said she, 'I have often thought of it.' Then she added in a low voice, 'And I will think of it again.'

my own vengeance I pursue, but the deliverance of a whole nation that I implore!

'Do you know him, then?' asked Felton.

'At length he interrogates me!' said Milady to herself, at the height of joy at having obtained so quickly such a great result. 'Oh, know him? Yes, yes! to my misfortune, to my eternal misfortune!' and Milady twisted her arms as if in a paroxysm of grief.

Felton no doubt felt within himself that his strength was abandoning him, and he made several steps toward the door; but the prisoner, whose eye never left him, sprang in pursuit of him and stopped him.

'Sir,' cried she, 'be kind, be clement, listen to my prayer! That knife, which the fatal prudence of the baron deprived me of, because he knows the use I would make of it! Oh, hear me to the end! that knife, give it to me for a minute only, for mercy's, for pity's sake! I will embrace your knees! You shall shut the door that you may be certain I contemplate no injury to you! My God! to you—the only just, good, and compassionate being I have met with! To you—my preserver, perhaps! One minute that knife, one minute, a single minute, and I will restore it to you through the grating of the door. Only one minute, Mr Felton, and you will have saved my honour!'

'To kill yourself?' cried Felton, with terror, forgetting to withdraw his hands from the hands of the prisoner, 'to kill yourself?'

'I have told, sir,' murmured Milady, lowering her voice, and allowing herself to sink overpowered to the ground; 'I have told my secret! He knows all! My God, I am lost!'

Felton remained standing, motionless and undecided.

'He still doubts,' thought Milady; 'I have not been earnest enough.'

Someone was heard in the corridor; Milady recognized the step of Lord de Winter.

Felton recognized it also, and made a step toward the door.

Milady sprang toward him. 'Oh, not a word,' said she in a concentrated voice, 'not a word of all that I have said to you to this man, or I am lost, and it would be you—you—'

Then as the steps drew near, she became silent for fear of being heard, applying, with a gesture of infinite terror, her beautiful hand to Felton's mouth.

'It is I who no longer understand you, madame,' said Felton.

'Or, rather, who pretend not to understand me, sir?' replied the prisoner, with a smile of incredulity.

'No, madame, on the honour of a soldier, on the faith of a Christian.'

'What, you are ignorant of Lord de Winter's designs upon me?'

'I am.'

'Impossible; you are his confidant!'

'I never lie, madame.'

'Oh, he conceals them too little for you not to divine them.'

'I seek to divine nothing, madame; I wait till I am confided in, and apart from that which Lord de Winter has said to me before you, he has confided nothing to me.'

'Why, then,' cried Milady, with an incredible tone of truthfulness, 'you are not his accomplice; you do not know that he destines me to a disgrace which all the punishments of the world cannot equal in horror?'

'You are deceived, madame,' said Felton, blushing; 'Lord de Winter is not capable of such a crime.'

'Good,' said Milady to herself; 'without thinking what it is, he calls it a crime! Then aloud, 'The friend of that wretch is capable of everything.'

'Whom do you call *that wretch*?' asked Felton.

'Are there, then, in England two men to whom such an epithet can be applied?'

'You mean George Villiers?' asked Felton, whose looks became excited.

'Whom Pagans and unbelieving Gentiles call Duke of Buckingham,' replied Milady. 'I could not have thought that there was an Englishman in all England who would have required so long an explanation to make him understand of whom I was speaking.'

'The hand of the Lord is stretched over him,' said Felton; 'he will not escape the chastisement he deserves.'

Felton only expressed, with regard to the duke, the feeling of execration which all the English had declared toward him whom the Catholics themselves called the extortioner, the pillager, the debauchee, and whom the Puritans styled simply Satan.

'Oh, my God, my God!' cried Milady; 'when I supplicate thee to pour upon this man the chastisement which is his due, thou knowest it is not

Felton felt a shudder run to the marrow of his bones; probably Lord de Winter perceived this emotion.

'Mistrust yourself, John,' said he. 'I have placed reliance upon you, my friend. Beware! I have warned you! But be of good courage, my lad; in three days we shall be delivered from this creature, and where I shall send her she can harm nobody.'

'You hear him!' cried Milady, with vehemence, so that the baron might believe she was addressing heaven, and that Felton might understand she was addressing him.

Felton lowered his head and reflected.

The baron took the young officer by the arm, and turned his head over his shoulder, so as not to lose sight of Milady till he was gone out.

'Well,' said the prisoner, when the door was shut, 'I am not so far advanced as I believed. De Winter has changed his usual stupidity into a strange prudence. It is the desire of vengeance, and how desire molds a man! As to Felton, he hesitates. Ah, he is not a man like that cursed D'Artagnan. A Puritan only adores virgins, and he adores them by clasp ing his hands. A Musketeer loves women, and he loves them by clasping his arms round them.'

Milady waited, then, with much impatience, for she feared the day would pass away without her seeing Felton again. At last, in an hour after the scene we have just described, she heard someone speaking in a low voice at the door. Presently the door opened, and she perceived Felton.

The young man advanced rapidly into the chamber, leaving the door open behind him, and making a sign to Milady to be silent; his face was much agitated.

'What do you want with me?' said she.

'Listen,' replied Felton, in a low voice. 'I have just sent away the sentinel that I might remain here without anybody knowing it, in order to speak to you without being overheard. The baron has just related a frightful story to me.'

Milady assumed her smile of a resigned victim, and shook her head.

'Either you are a demon,' continued Felton, 'or the baron—my benefactor, my father—is a monster. I have known you four days; I have loved him four years. I therefore may hesitate between you. Be not alarmed at

what I say; I want to be convinced. Tonight, after twelve, I will come and see you, and you shall convince me.'

'No, Felton, no, my brother,' said she; 'the sacrifice is too great, and I feel what it must cost you. No, I am lost; do not be lost with me. My death will be much more eloquent than my life, and the silence of the corpse will convince you much better than the words of the prisoner.'

'Be silent, madame,' cried Felton, 'and do not speak to me thus; I came to entreat you to promise me upon your honour, to swear to me by what you hold most sacred, that you will make no attempt upon your life.'

'I will not promise,' said Milady, 'for no one has more respect for a promise or an oath than I have; and if I make a promise I must keep it.'

'Well,' said Felton, 'only promise till you have seen me again. If, when you have seen me again, you still persist—well, then you shall be free, and I myself will give you the weapon you desire.'

'Well,' said Milady, 'for you I will wait.'

'Swear.'

'I swear it, by our God. Are you satisfied?'

'Well,' said Felton, 'till tonight.'

And he darted out of the room, shut the door, and waited in the corridor, the soldier's half-pike in his hand, and as if he had mounted guard in his place.

The soldier returned, and Felton gave him back his weapon.

Then, through the grating to which she had drawn near, Milady saw the young man make a sign with delirious fervour, and depart in an apparent transport of joy.

As for her, she returned to her place with a smile of savage contempt upon her lips, and repeated, blaspheming, that terrible name of God, by whom she had just sworn without ever having learned to know Him.

'My God,' said she, 'what a senseless fanatic! My God, it is I—I—and this fellow who will help me to avenge myself.'

Then only she pretended to hear the sound of Felton's steps, and rising quick as thought, she blushed, as if ashamed of being surprised on her knees.

'I do not like to disturb those who pray, madame,' said Felton, seriously; 'do not disturb yourself on my account, I beseech you.'

'How do you know I was praying, sir?' said Milady, in a voice broken by sobs. 'You were deceived, sir; I was not praying.'

'Do you think, then, madame,' replied Felton, in the same serious voice, but with a milder tone, 'do you think I assume the right of preventing a creature from prostrating herself before her Creator? God forbid! Besides, repentance becomes the guilty; whatever crimes they may have committed, for me the guilty are sacred at the feet of God!'

'Guilty? I?' said Milady, with a smile which might have disarmed the angel of the last judgment. 'Guilty? Oh, my God, thou knowest whether I am guilty! Say I am condemned, sir, if you please; but you know that God, who loves martyrs, sometimes permits the innocent to be condemned.'

'Were you condemned, were you innocent, were you a martyr,' replied Felton, 'the greater would be the necessity for prayer; and I myself would aid you with my prayers.'

'Oh, you are a just man!' cried Milady, throwing herself at his feet. 'I can hold out no longer, for I fear I shall be wanting in strength at the moment when I shall be forced to undergo the struggle, and confess my faith. Listen, then, to the supplication of a despairing woman. You are abused, sir; but that is not the question. I only ask you one favour; and if you grant it me, I will bless you in this world and in the next.'

'Speak to the master, madame,' said Felton; 'happily I am neither charged with the power of pardoning nor punishing. It is upon one higher placed than I am that God has laid this responsibility.'

'To you—no, to you alone! Listen to me, rather than add to my destruction, rather than add to my ignominy.'

'If you have merited this shame, madame, if you have incurred this ignominy, you must submit to it as an offering to God.'

'What do you say? Oh, you do not understand me! When I speak of ignominy, you think I speak of some chastisement, of imprisonment or death. Would to heaven! Of what consequence to me is imprisonment or death?'

effort to control himself, he sent back to his heart the words that were about to escape from his lips, and went out. Toward midday, Lord de Winter entered.

It was a tolerably fine winter's day, and a ray of that pale English sun which lights but does not warm came through the bars of her prison.

Milady was looking out at the window, and pretended not to hear the door as it opened.

'Ah, ah!' said Lord de Winter, 'after having played comedy, after having played tragedy, we are now playing melancholy?'

The prisoner made no reply.

'Yes, yes,' continued Lord de Winter, 'I understand. You would like very well to be at liberty on that beach! You would like very well to be in a good ship dancing upon the waves of that emerald-green sea; you would like very well, either on land or on the ocean, to lay for me one of those nice little ambushades you are so skilful in planning. Patience, patience! In four days' time the shore will be beneath your feet, the sea will be open to you—more open than will perhaps be agreeable to you, for in four days England will be relieved of you.'

Milady folded her hands, and raising her fine eyes toward heaven, 'Lord, Lord,' said she, with an angelic meekness of gesture and tone, 'pardon this man, as I myself pardon him.'

'Yes, pray, accursed woman!' cried the baron; 'your prayer is so much the more generous from your being, I swear to you, in the power of a man who will never pardon you!' and he went out.

At the moment he went out a piercing glance darted through the opening of the nearly closed door, and she perceived Felton, who drew quickly to one side to prevent being seen by her.

Then she threw herself upon her knees, and began to pray.

'My God, my God!' said she, 'thou knowest in what holy cause I suffer; give me, then, strength to suffer.'

The door opened gently; the beautiful supplicant pretended not to hear the noise, and in a voice broken by tears, she continued:

'God of vengeance! God of goodness! wilt thou allow the frightful projects of this man to be accomplished?'

Chapter LVI

Captivity: The Fifth Day



MILADY had however achieved a half-triumph, and success doubled her forces.

It was not difficult to conquer, as she had hitherto done, men prompt to let themselves be seduced, and whom the gallant education of a court led quickly into her net. Milady was handsome enough not to find much resistance on the part of the flesh, and she was sufficiently skilful to prevail over all the obstacles of the mind.

But this time she had to contend with an unpolished nature, concentrated and insensible by force of austerity. Religion and its observances had made Felton a man inaccessible to ordinary seductions. There fermented in that sublimated brain plans so vast, projects so tumultuous, that there remained no room for any capricious or material love—that sentiment which is fed by leisure and grows with corruption. Milady had, then, made a breach by her false virtue in the opinion of a man horribly prejudiced against her, and by her beauty in the heart of a man hitherto chaste and pure. In short, she had taken the measure of motives hitherto unknown to herself, through this experiment, made upon the most rebellious subject that nature and religion could submit to her study.

Many a time, nevertheless, during the evening she despaired of fate and of herself. She did not invoke God, we very well know, but she had faith in the genius of evil—that immense sovereignty which reigns in all the details of human life, and by which, as in the Arabian fable, a single pomegranate seed is sufficient to reconstruct a ruined world.

Milady, being well prepared for the reception of Felton, was able to erect her batteries for the next day. She knew she had only two days left;

that when once the order was signed by Buckingham—and Buckingham would sign it the more readily from its bearing a false name, and he could not, therefore, recognize the woman in question—once this order was signed, we say, the baron would make her embark immediately, and she knew very well that women condemned to exile employ arms much less powerful in their seductions than the pretendedly virtuous woman whose beauty is lighted by the sun of the world, whose style the voice of fashion lauds, and whom a halo of aristocracy gilds with enchanting splendours. To be a woman condemned to a painful and disgraceful punishment is no impediment to beauty, but it is an obstacle to the recovery of power. Like all persons of real genius, Milady knew what suited her nature and her means. Poverty was repugnant to her; degradation took away two-thirds of her greatness. Milady was only a queen while among queens. The pleasure of satisfied pride was necessary to her domination. To command inferior beings was rather a humiliation than a pleasure for her.

She should certainly return from her exile—she did not doubt that a single instant, but how long might this exile last? For an active, ambitious nature, like that of Milady, days not spent in climbing are inauspicious days. What word, then, can be found to describe the days which they occupy in descending? To lose a year, two years, three years, is to talk of an eternity; to return after the death or disgrace of the cardinal, perhaps, to return when D'Artagnan and his friends, happy and triumphant, should have received from the queen the reward they had well acquired by the services they had rendered her—these were devouring ideas that a woman like Milady could not endure. For the rest, the storm which raged within her doubled her strength, and she would have burst the walls of her prison if her body had been able to take for a single instant the proportions of her mind.

Then that which spurred her on additionally in the midst of all this was the remembrance of the cardinal. What must the mistrustful, restless, suspicious cardinal think of her silence—the cardinal, not merely her only support, her only prop, her only protector at present, but still further, the principal instrument of her future fortune and vengeance? She knew him; she knew that at her return from a fruitless journey it would be in vain to tell him of her imprisonment, in vain to enlarge upon the sufferings she had undergone. The cardinal would reply, with the sarcastic calmness

Chapter LIV

Captivity: The Third Day



FELTON had fallen; but there was still another step to be taken. He must be retained, or rather he must be left quite alone; and Milady but obscurely perceived the means which could lead to this result.

Still more must be done. He must be made to speak, in order that he might be spoken to—for Milady very well knew that her greatest seduction was in her voice, which so skilfully ran over the whole gamut of tones from human speech to language celestial.

Yet in spite of all this seduction Milady might fail—for Felton was forewarned, and that against the least chance. From that moment she watched all his actions, all his words, from the simplest glance of his eyes to his gestures—even to a breath that could be interpreted as a sigh. In short, she studied everything; as a skilful comedian does to whom a new part has been assigned in a line to which he is not accustomed.

Face to face with Lord de Winter her plan of conduct was more easy. She had laid that down the preceding evening. To remain silent and dignified in his presence; from time to time to irritate him by affected disdain, by a contemptuous word; to provoke him to threats and violence which would produce a contrast with her own resignation—such was her plan. Felton would see all; perhaps he would say nothing, but he would see.

In the morning, Felton came as usual; but Milady allowed him to preside over all the preparations for breakfast without addressing a word to him. At the moment when he was about to retire, she was cheered with a ray of hope, for she thought he was about to speak; but his lips moved without any sound leaving his mouth, and making a powerful